

Ancient-Medieval History

Early Medieval(700-1526AD)

Exam: UPSC CSE (Prelims)

1. Pratiharas-Palas-Rashtrakutas

Tier: tier2 • Weightage: 3.704 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 3 • Year span: 2006–2022 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:26

TopicDemandMap: Pratiharas-Palas-Rashtrakutas (Early Medieval, 700–1526 AD)

Explicitly Tested Subtopics

1. Founders and Foundation of Dynasties

- **Evidence:** [2006]
- Focuses on identification of the founder of the Rashtrakuta Empire.
- Tests knowledge of key personalities who established major early medieval dynasties.

2. Chronology of Major Dynastic Events

- **Evidence:** [745]
- Requires arranging the rise/foundation of Pratiharas, Palas, and other contemporary dynasties in correct chronological order.
- Emphasizes understanding of temporal relationships among early medieval powers.

3. King-Dynasty Associations

- **Evidence:** [993]
- Tests the ability to correctly match prominent kings (e.g., Nagabhata II, Bhoja) with their respective dynasties (e.g., Gurjara-Pratihara, Rashtrakuta).
- Involves distinguishing between rulers of different but contemporaneous dynasties.

Logical Study Sequence

1 Founders and Foundation of Dynasties

(Basic identification of who established which dynasty; foundational for understanding subsequent developments.)

1 King-Dynasty Associations

(Requires knowledge of both founders and later prominent rulers, as well as their dynastic affiliations.)

1 Chronology of Major Dynastic Events

(Builds on previous knowledge to sequence events and understand the historical context.)

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- **Familiarity with Major Early Medieval Dynasties:**

Basic awareness of the Pratiharas, Palas, Rashtrakutas, and their contemporaries (e.g., Cholas, Pallavas, Chandelas, Paramaras).

- **Ability to Distinguish Between Similar-Sounding Names and Dynasties:**

Avoiding confusion between rulers with similar names or overlapping timeframes.

- **Understanding of Historical Chronology:**

Placing events and reigns in correct temporal order, including knowledge of approximate dates.

- **Awareness of Regional Distribution:**

Knowing the geographical domains of these dynasties, though not directly tested, is helpful for chronology and association questions.

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- **Major Battles and Conflicts Among Pratiharas, Palas, and Rashtrakutas:**

(E.g., Tripartite Struggle for Kannauj)

- **Administrative and Cultural Contributions of These Dynasties:**

(E.g., art, architecture, literature, governance)

- **Decline and Succession of Dynasties:**

(Causes and consequences of the decline of these powers)

- **Relations with Contemporary Foreign Powers or Other Indian Kingdoms:**

(E.g., interactions with Arab invaders, alliances, and rivalries)

- **Socio-Economic Conditions Under These Dynasties:**

(Land grants, trade, society)

Notes:

- The current PYQ set is limited (3 questions), restricting the granularity of subtopic mapping. All identified subtopics are directly evidenced by the questions provided.
- No PYQs in this set test deeper aspects such as administration, culture, or military campaigns of these dynasties, but these remain logical adjacent areas for future UPSC focus.

2. Chera-Chola-Pandya

Tier: tier3 • Weightage: 3.704 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 7 • Year span: 1993–2023 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:25

TopicDemandMap: Chera-Chola-Pandya (Early Medieval South India, 700–1526 AD)

Explicit Subtopics Tested

1. Chola Art and Iconography

- **Evidence:** [4881, 4879]
- Focus on the significance and features of Chola bronze sculptures, especially the Nataraja icon, and their place in world art history.

2. Chola Administration and Village Institutions

- **Evidence:** [4882, 307]
- Questions on inscriptions (e.g., Uttaramerur) as sources for understanding Chola village administration, and terminology related to land grants, village structure, and educational institutions (e.g., Eripatti, Taniyurs, Ghatikas).

3. Chola Military Expansion and Foreign Campaigns

- **Evidence:** [1348, 1608]
- Coverage of Chola military conquests, including campaigns against the Pandyas, Cheras, Ceylon (Sri Lanka), and expeditions to Southeast Asia (Sailendra empire).

4. Major Ports and Urban Centres of Ancient South India

- **Evidence:** [1004]
- Identification and significance of major port towns (Korkai, Poompuhar, Muchiri) associated with the Chera, Chola, and Pandya realms.

Logical Study Sequence

1 Major Ports and Urban Centres of Ancient South India

(Foundation: Geographical and economic context)

1 Chola Art and Iconography

(Cultural achievements rooted in urban and temple centres)

1 Chola Administration and Village Institutions

(Political and social organization supporting cultural and economic life)

1 Chola Military Expansion and Foreign Campaigns

(Advanced: Political history, external relations, and impact)

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Basic chronology and territorial extent of Chera, Chola, and Pandya dynasties
- Understanding of South Indian temple culture and its socio-political role
- Familiarity with inscriptional evidence as a historical source
- Knowledge of South Indian trade networks and maritime activity
- Awareness of the relationship between land grants, temple economy, and education

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Religious movements and Bhakti traditions under the Chera, Chola, and Pandya dynasties
- Socio-economic structure: caste, agrarian relations, and temple economy
- Architectural developments (temple construction, urban planning)
- Literary contributions (Tamil Sangam literature, court poetry)
- Administrative comparison with contemporary northern Indian polities
- Role of women and social customs in early medieval South India

Notes

- The PYQs cover a moderate range of subtopics, with a clear focus on Chola achievements (art, administration, military) and some attention to broader South Indian urban and economic history.
- The number of questions is sufficient to identify recurring themes, but coverage of Chera and Pandya dynasties is less direct, mostly appearing in relation to Chola expansion.
- Some subtopics (e.g., religious and literary developments) are not yet directly tested but are logical extensions for future UPSC questions.

3. Dynasties of the North

Tier: tier1 • Weightage: 11.111 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 13 • Year span: 1994–2020 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:26

TopicDemandMap: Dynasties of the North (Early Medieval, 700–1526 AD)

Explicitly Tested Subtopics

1. Major Dynasties and Their Territories

- **Evidence:** 4876, 136, 4878
- **Notes:** Questions focus on identifying dynasties (Gupta, Chandela, Chalukya, Pallava), mapping medieval states to present regions, and tracing the routes or exploits of rulers (e.g., Harshavardhana). This tests both dynastic identification and their geographical-political extent.

2. Administrative and Social Structure

- **Evidence:** 222, 1232, 156, 750
- **Notes:** Coverage includes village-level officers (Mahattara, Pattakila), features and origins of the feudal system, elements of land administration (land measurement terms like kulyavapa, dronavapa), and the emergence of lord-vassal relationships. This subtopic emphasizes the functioning and evolution of local and feudal administration.

3. Foreign Accounts and Travelers

- **Evidence:** 7, 5022
- **Notes:** Questions test knowledge of foreign travelers (Yuan Chwang/Hiuen Tsang, Marco Polo) and their observations on Indian society, administration, and culture during the period.

4. Invasions and External Influences

- **Evidence:** 2007, 1235
- **Notes:** Focus on the chronological order of foreign invaders (Greeks, Sakas, Kushans) and the introduction of administrative practices such as military governorship by external powers.

5. Cultural and Intellectual Life

- **Evidence:** 4880, 316
- **Notes:** Includes references to literary figures (Kalidasa) in inscriptions and the role of professionals (Maagadha) in preserving dynastic histories and epics, reflecting the intellectual and cultural milieu.

Logical Study Sequence

1 Major Dynasties and Their Territories

(Foundational understanding of who ruled where and when)

1 Invasions and External Influences

(How external powers shaped the region's history and administration)

1 Administrative and Social Structure

(How governance and society were organized under these dynasties)

1 Cultural and Intellectual Life

(Cultural achievements and the preservation of history)

1 Foreign Accounts and Travelers

(External perspectives and records of Indian society and polity)

Implicit Concepts and Prerequisites

- **Map Reading and Geographical Correlation:**

Required to answer questions involving routes, territorial extent, and matching historical regions to modern geography.

- **Chronological Reasoning:**

Understanding the sequence of dynasties, invasions, and administrative changes.

- **Basic Epigraphy and Numismatics:**

Recognizing the significance of inscriptions and land measurement terms.

- **Socio-political Terminology:**

Familiarity with terms like feudalism, lord-vassal, and administrative titles.

- **Historical Source Analysis:**

Ability to interpret information from foreign travelers and indigenous records.

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- **Religious Developments and Patronage:**

The role of northern dynasties in supporting or transforming religious institutions and practices.

- **Urbanization and Economic Changes:**

Growth of towns, trade routes, and economic policies under these dynasties.

- **Art and Architecture:**

Architectural contributions (temples, forts) and their dynastic associations.

- **Military Organization and Warfare:**

Structure of armies, military campaigns, and innovations in warfare.

- **Women and Social Groups:**

Status and roles of women, and the functioning of various social groups under northern dynasties.

Notes

- The PYQ set covers a broad but not exhaustive range of subtopics; some areas (e.g., art, religion) are not directly represented.

- Subtopic division is based strictly on patterns in the provided PYQs; further granularity is limited by the available evidence.
- Some questions require cross-period knowledge (e.g., invasions, feudalism origins), indicating the need for a comparative approach within the study plan.

4. Dynasties of the Deccan and South India

Tier: tier2 • Weightage: 5.556 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 8 • Year span: 1997–2023 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:26

TopicDemandMap: Dynasties of the Deccan and South India (Early Medieval, 700–1526 AD)

Explicitly Tested Subtopics

Merchant Guilds and Trade Networks

- **Evidence:** [4874, 5015]
- Focus on identification and roles of merchant guilds such as Manigramam and Nanadesi.
- Questions test recognition of these organizations and their economic significance in South Indian society.

Monumental Architecture and Art

- **Evidence:** [1349]
- Identification of key sites associated with specific dynasties (e.g., Hoysala monuments at Halebid and Belur).
- Emphasis on linking dynasties to their architectural contributions.

Maritime Trade and Cultural Contacts

- **Evidence:** [2664, 402]
- Examination of factors enabling maritime trade (e.g., shipbuilding, monsoon winds, royal patronage).
- Identification of important seaports (e.g., Motupalli under the Kakatiyas) and their roles in external trade.

Political Foundations and Dynastic Origins

- **Evidence:** [148, 1006]
- Recognition of founders, foundation myths, and early establishment of dynasties (e.g., city founding, divine agency).

- Chronological awareness of when major dynasties (Hoysala, Kakatiya, Yadava, Gahadavala) emerged.

Feudal Structures and Administration

- **Evidence:** [5023]
- Understanding of revenue assignments (e.g., Bhoga) and the roles of hereditary chiefs.
- Focus on administrative and landholding patterns characteristic of early medieval South India.

Logical Study Sequence

1 Political Foundations and Dynastic Origins

(Basic awareness of dynasties, founders, chronology)

1 Feudal Structures and Administration

(Understanding governance, land assignments, local chiefs)

1 Merchant Guilds and Trade Networks

(Economic structures, merchant organizations)

1 Maritime Trade and Cultural Contacts

(External trade, seaports, cultural exchanges)

1 Monumental Architecture and Art

(Dynastic contributions to art and architecture)

Implicit Concepts and Prerequisites

- **Geographical Awareness:**

Knowledge of South Indian geography (rivers, cities, ports) is needed to locate dynasties, architectural sites, and trade centers.

- **Chronological Reasoning:**

Ability to sequence dynasties and events within the early medieval period.

- **Socio-Economic Structures:**

Understanding of how guilds, feudal lords, and administrative units interacted.

- **Terminology:**

Familiarity with terms like Bhoga, Manigramam, Nanadesi, and their context.

- **Inter-dynastic Relations:**

Awareness of how different dynasties interacted or coexisted, even if not directly asked.

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- **Religious Movements and Patronage:**

Influence of dynasties on the spread of religious sects (Shaivism, Vaishnavism, Jainism, Buddhism).

- **Literature and Language:**

Literary contributions and the development of regional languages under these dynasties.

- **Military Organization and Warfare:**

Structure of armies, notable battles, and military innovations in the Deccan and South India.

- **Urbanization and City Life:**

Growth of urban centers, civic administration, and urban society.

- **Women and Social Structure:**

Roles of women, social hierarchies, and caste dynamics in early medieval South India.

Notes

- The PYQ set covers a moderate range of subtopics, but the sample size (8 questions) limits granularity.

- Most questions focus on identification and recognition rather than analytical depth.
- Subtopics are merged where overlap is evident to avoid artificial fragmentation.
- Adjacent subtopics are inferred based on logical extension from tested areas, not from external syllabi.

5. Dynasties of East and North-East

Tier: tier3 • Weightage: 0.0 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 2 • Year span: 2006–2015 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:25

TopicDemandMap: Dynasties of East and North-East (Early Medieval, 700–1526 AD)

Explicitly Tested Subtopics

1. Patronage of Religions by Dynasties of Eastern India

- **Evidence:** [2008]
- Focuses on the relationship between ruling dynasties (e.g., Palas) and their support or opposition to major religions, specifically Buddhism.

2. Identification of Rulers and Their Core Regions in Eastern and North-Eastern India

- **Evidence:** [5021]
- Tests knowledge of prominent rulers (e.g., Shashanka, Bhaskara Varman) and the geographical regions they governed.

Logical Study Sequence

1 Identification of Rulers and Their Core Regions in Eastern and North-Eastern India

- Foundational for understanding the political landscape and context of subsequent religious or cultural developments.

1 Patronage of Religions by Dynasties of Eastern India

- Builds on ruler identification to analyze their policies and cultural impact.

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Basic chronology and geography of early medieval Eastern and North-Eastern India.
- Recognition of major dynasties and rulers (names, timelines).

- Awareness of the spread and influence of religions (especially Buddhism) in the region.
- Ability to match historical figures to their respective regions and dynasties.

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Administrative systems and governance structures of Eastern and North-Eastern dynasties.
- Socio-economic contributions and cultural achievements (art, architecture, literature) of these dynasties.
- Interactions and conflicts among Eastern, North-Eastern, and neighboring dynasties.
- Role of these dynasties in regional trade and external relations (e.g., with Southeast Asia).

Notes

- The current PYQ count is small (2), limiting the granularity of subtopic identification.
- Both questions emphasize factual recall (ruler-region mapping, religious patronage) rather than analytical or thematic depth.
- Future questions may expand into administrative, cultural, or inter-dynastic aspects as logical extensions of the current pattern.

6. DELHI SULTANATE

Tier: tier1 • Weightage: 14.815 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 34 • Year span: 1993–2022 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:25

TopicDemandMap: DELHI SULTANATE (Ancient-Medieval History > Early Medieval (700–1526 AD))

Explicit Subtopics Tested

1. Major Dynasties and Succession

- Identification of dynasties (Slave, Khalji, Tughlaq, Lodhi) and their rulers
- Chronological order and succession of rulers
- Evidence: 4871, 1765, 2024, 1627, 1630

Notes: Questions focus on recognizing dynastic order, last rulers, and key succession events.

2. Administrative and Revenue Systems

- Iqta system, revenue collection, and related offices (Amil, Jagir, Fawazil)
- Administrative divisions (Paragana, Sarkar, Suba)
- Evidence: 1254, 4872, 5019, 673, 846, 5024

Notes: Emphasis on understanding administrative structures and revenue mechanisms unique to the Sultanate.

3. Military Organization and Mongol Invasions

- Military reforms, departments, branding of horses, Turkan-i-Chihalgani
- Mongol invasions: chronology, impact, and responses
- Use of siege technology (munjaniq)
- Evidence: 1371, 5017, 1369, 839, 958, 5018, 5016

Notes: Questions test both internal military administration and external threats, especially Mongol invasions.

4. Economic Policies and Market Regulation

- Market control, price regulation, land revenue reforms
- Irrigation and canal construction
- Use of technology (Araghatta)
- Evidence: 5020, 4873, 315

Notes: Focus on Alauddin Khalji's market reforms and infrastructural developments by Sultans.

5. Religious and Cultural Policies

- Sufism and Bhakti movement interactions with the Sultanate
- Religious tolerance, state and Islamic law, festivals (Navroz)
- Evidence: 1476, 1476, 1498, 53, 4883, 1497

Notes: Questions probe the Sultanate's approach to religion, Sufi orders, and cultural practices.

6. Notable Personalities and Foreign Visitors

- Travelers (Ibn Battuta, Marco Polo)
- Historians (Barani)
- Evidence: 4884, 5024, 1498

Notes: Focus on the accounts and roles of foreign travelers and historians in the Sultanate period.

7. Important Events and Policies of Specific Rulers

- Capital transfer, coinage reforms, canal building, responses to crises
- Evidence: 5025, 2023, 1497, 4873

Notes: Questions target major policy decisions and their motivations/consequences.

8. Social Groups and Terminology

- Identification of groups (Kulah-Daran, Sayyids, Qalandars)
- Evidence: 959

Notes: Tests knowledge of social categories and their relevance in Sultanate society.

Logical Study Sequence

- 1 Major Dynasties and Succession
- 2 Administrative and Revenue Systems
- 3 Military Organization and Mongol Invasions
- 4 Economic Policies and Market Regulation
- 5 Religious and Cultural Policies
- 6 Notable Personalities and Foreign Visitors
- 7 Important Events and Policies of Specific Rulers

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Basic chronology of medieval India and transition from Rajput to Sultanate rule
- Understanding of Persian/Arabic administrative terms
- Map-based awareness of medieval Indian geography (for battles, capitals, invasions)
- General knowledge of medieval military technology and siege warfare
- Familiarity with religious movements (Sufism, Bhakti) and their timelines
- Comparative understanding of administrative systems (Sultanate vs. later empires)

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Urbanization and city life under the Sultanate
- Art, architecture, and literature patronized by the Sultans
- Role and status of women in Sultanate society
- Provincial administration and local governance
- Sultanate's relations with South Indian kingdoms and foreign powers
- Economic impact of Sultanate policies on agrarian society
- Decline and legacy of the Delhi Sultanate

Notes

- The PYQ set is substantial and allows for confident identification of subtopics.
- Some subtopics (e.g., social groups, technology) have limited coverage but are distinct in the pattern.
- Overlaps between subtopics (e.g., administrative and economic policies) are resolved by assigning each question to the most representative subtopic.
- Adjacent subtopics are inferred based on logical extension of tested themes, not on external syllabus lists.